

of a strategy to avoid civilian targets and thus escape the tag of being a terrorist group which Colombo has consistently been trying to label it with. "We will never attack civilian targets," Ilanthirayan said. It is not only an assault on the island's military establishment but also a blow to President Mahinda Rajapakse's relentless onslaught on the rebels who stepped up their attacks on civilians and the security forces shortly after his election in December 2005.

Following the attack, the main Opposition United National Party called for the resignation of Defence Secretary Gotabaya Rajapakse, President Rajapakse's brother, and

Last year, the Government had started an all-out military campaign that included aerial bombing and artillery shelling. The Tigers' last eastern stronghold of Thoppigala was taken over this July and, since then, the Government has claimed a series of successful strikes, including the sinking of 10 alleged Tiger ships on high seas, said to be smuggling arms to LTTE bases in the north and the east.

With the Government pinning hopes on its military victories, the Anuradhapura attack comes as an embarrassment. However, defence spokesman Keheliya Rambukwelle

rights record as a large number of extra-judicial killings, abductions and disappearances of minority Tamils go uninvestigated. In the east, Karuna, a former Black Tigers commander whose paramilitary group is taking on LTTE in the areas under their control, has been facing the threat of a split in his own ranks. Despite the instability in the region, the Government has already announced a campaign to liberate the northern districts where LTTE still commands huge areas of territory.

Ironically, despite violence snowballing steadily since President Rajapakse came to power in 2005, the tattered ceasefire brokered by Norway



Air Force Chief Roshan Gunatilleke, who according to the Opposition were responsible for not averting the attack despite similar incidents earlier this year. As a consequence, there were some changes in the top military posts a day after the incident. The air force was relieved of the responsibility of guarding the outer perimeter of the country's military airports and the responsibility was passed on to the army instead. However, a Sri Lankan military spokesperson denied that their operational capability had been dented following the Anuradhapura assault. "Our operations against them are continuing without respite and we conducted air raids on their airstrip at Iranamadu soon after the strike," army spokesperson Brigadier Udaya Nanayakkara said.

ARMS AND THE MEN: LTTE chief Prabhakaran (centre) with his squad described the attack as a ploy to divert the attention of the security forces after troops had captured swathes of Tiger territory in the eastern part of the country. "We are not deterred and will continue the thrust on LTTE to liberate the people in the north from their grip to ensure their democratic rights," Rambukwelle was quoted as saying in the state-run newspaper, *Daily News*.

The Government has also been planning extensive development of the eastern districts of Trincomalee, Batticaloa and Ampara for which it has sought foreign assistance. However, the international community has been increasingly demanding improvements in the country's human

in 2002 is yet to be formally abrogated by the Government and the rebels. The Sri Lanka Monitoring Mission, a group of Icelanders supervising the truce, is still functioning, even as over 5,000 people have been killed and thousands more have been forced to flee their homes in the last 22 months.

"As a military operation, Monday's pre-dawn attack on the Anuradhapura airbase was a success, but in the long run such casualties will become unbearable forcing the Tigers to talk peace soon," former military intelligence officer Colonel (ret'd) R. Hariharan said. With the Government determined to take on the rebels, the Tigers may launch similar assaults on military bases to keep it engaged.

with Sandeep Unnithan